Girl, So Confusing:

Why Virality Without Policy Fails to Persuade

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Kamala Harris launched her campaign just 107 days prior to the 2024 election, following Joe Biden's exit after a poor debate, low approval rating, and concerns about his age. Harris not only faced a truncated campaign timeline but also inherited the economic dissatisfaction tied to the Biden administration and the uphill battle of being a Black woman seeking the presidency. Her campaign had to navigate her failed 2019 progressive image with her record as a prosecutor, "border czar" and vice president, all within an unprecedented compressed campaign timeline. Despite these challenges, her campaign appeared to have an opportunity when the "coconut tree" meme went viral, coinciding with Charlie XCX's brat summer. The campaign leaned into this moment, attempting to transform Harris into a culturally relevant, self-aware candidate who could bridge generational and partisan divides.

This paper argues that Kamala Harris's Brat Summer campaign strategy confirmed support among existing Democratic voters and briefly energized young online audiences, but ultimately failed because her cultural meme-based messaging clashed with her moderate, law and order policy appeals amid economic dissatisfaction and incumbent fatigue. While the Brat aesthetic and memes achieved virality, it failed to convert digital attention into measurable shifts in voter attitudes or turnout, demonstrating that visibility alone cannot overcome economic frustration. This analysis will examine Harris's campaign strategy by investigating the campaign's strategy of memes and pop culture, the implementation of this strategy, its target audience and consequences, and finally, its overall effectiveness. Combining Joshua Narrel's (2025) quantitative study of meme-based political participation with theories of voter behavior, and comparing Harris's approach to that of Zohran Mamdani's, who has similarly used virality to engage voters, this paper illustrates that cultural engagement alone cannot overcome poor policy messaging.

The Harris campaign tried to modernize her image and connect with younger and queer voters by presenting her as culturally fluent and relatable, distancing her from Biden's image. Her social media team prioritized platform-specific messaging, using TikTok to connect with young voters through memes. The Brat trend with its ironic and rebellious aesthetic seemed like the perfect trend to realign Harris's brand from a stiff establishment politician to self-aware and culturally fluent. Sides (2006) explains that campaigns set agendas to redirect attention away from policy weaknesses. Harris's team treated the Brat summer as agenda substitution, using cultural phenomena as short-term cues to distract from criticisms of Harris's platform. This shift prioritized personality over policy, limiting its effectiveness in the polls.

While Harris's social media strategy targeted young voters, her more general messaging through advertisements, debates, and interviews targeted moderates and non-Trump Republicans, emphasizing a more bipartisan and law and order approach. The clash between a rebellious culture and a cautious moderate approach left voters confused about her platform. Analysts like Gaddini and Figueras-Pont (2024) and Galston (2025) highlight this confusion, noting that voters struggled to identify a consistent message from the Harris campaign. Moderates encountering the memes perceived the campaign as unserious. This problem aligns with Ahler and Sood's (2018) findings that Americans hold exaggerated stereotypes about party coalitions. By embracing Brat, Harris reinforced the image of Democrats being urban, young, and queer, intensifying polarization rather than broadening her support base. Harris's campaign effectively alienated moderates. Similarly, Theiss-Morse and Wagner (2023) argue that modern elections are dominated by affective partisanship, voters' emotional loyalty to their party identities. Cultural messaging energizes existing supporters rather than persuading new ones. Harris's aesthetic

strategy, therefore, reinforced Democratic enthusiasm online without expanding her coalition or motivating new turnout.

These effects of polarization were further intensified by the increased scrutiny Harris faced from moral and gendered expectations, as outlined by Wagner (2021). Her identity as a woman meant that it was much harder for her to convince voters of her authenticity and ability. The consequence of her dual strategy was the illusion of online momentum and an unclear policy platform, leaving both progressives and moderates uncertain about what Harris stood for. As the campaign continued, the disconnect between appearance and substance became even more visible in how her media operation functioned.

The Harris campaign tried to balance grassroots support, and a carefully orchestrated media strategy through coordination between her media team and paid influencers. Her campaign spread across TikTok, Instagram, X, Facebook, and Threads, where official accounts shared self-aware “coconut tree” memes and the Brat green aesthetic to capture young voters (Mull, 2024). Influencers boosted these messages, spreading meme-based political messaging to their own audiences. A Wired investigation revealed that a dark-money nonprofit financed many of the Democratic-leaning influencers that promoted Harris and her Brat campaign during the election. The payments were routed so that it was impossible to determine the scope of the partnerships and funding (Lorenz, 2025). This meant that what appeared to be spontaneous viral momentum was partly an engineered marketing campaign. This strategy ultimately undermined the authenticity that Brat was meant to convey, adding to criticism that the rebrand was a top-down strategy rather than a genuine cultural moment.

Beyond the lack of authenticity, the campaign's reliance on Brat green graphics and ironic memes focused more on aesthetics than substantive policy communication. As McClurg (2006) found in his study, political communication fosters participation only when it happens in trusted networks with substantive discussion and understanding. Harris's Brat summer, on the other hand, acted as a one-way publicity campaign, increasing visibility online without sparking substantive policy engagement. Voters may have been more aware of the Harris campaign through social media, but it ultimately did not convince voters to show up for Harris in the polls.

Empirical evidence supports the idea that while the Harris campaign successfully generated online attention, it failed to translate that visibility into meaningful political participation. Joshua Narrell's (2025) survey experiment of young adults found that exposure to meme-based political content increased campaign awareness by roughly 0.18 standard deviations, a statistically significant boost in visibility, but produced no significant change in vote intention or perceptions of authenticity and trust. This evidence confirms that social-media visibility does not automatically translate into political behavior.

These communication and behavioral patterns align with the Michigan Model's broader explanation of voter decision-making. Campbell et al. (1960) argue that short-term campaign appeals are filtered through voters' preexisting partisan identities and retrospective evaluations of government performance. In 2024, those evaluations were overwhelmingly economic. The Harris campaign's emphasis on cultural fluency and bipartisanship offered little to address concerns about inflation, wages, or affordability, leaving her indistinguishable from the administration's economic record. Social media Brat branding functioned as a short-term cue that failed to overcome preexisting partisan filters, a dynamic predicted by the Michigan Model. Haas et al. (2025) describe 2024 as a "mandate for change," shaped by economic frustration and

declining real wages. By failing to articulate an economic agenda or distance herself from the status quo, Harris's campaign embodied continuity rather than change, transforming what could have been a highly visible campaign with appealing policies into a failed spectacle.

To test if virality can translate to electoral success, it's useful to compare Harris's strategy with a case of digital attention backed by substantive policy. In contrast to the Harris campaign, Zohran Mamdani's approach illustrates how a viral social-media strategy can succeed when it is grounded in concrete policy messaging. Although Mamdani's campaign is still ongoing and the full extent of his strategy's success cannot be measured, his digital approach already shows the impact of policy-based messaging on social media. As The New York Times Magazine (2025) reports, Mamdani's campaign structure centers on a deliberate, policy-first blueprint connecting every communication to a material proposal. His online content consistently ties humor or personality back to specific issues such as rent control, public power, and transit reform. This disciplined integration of policy and platform allows his digital reach to function as political education rather than distraction. As opposed to Harris's surface-level rebranding, Mamdani's messaging treats attention as a means to deepen understanding of economic policy.

A clear example of this strategy is how Mamdani used his appearance at a winter "Polar Bear Plunge" event to promote his Freeze the Rent policy proposal (Ogle, 2025). His team turned a seemingly insignificant viral stunt into a response to New Yorkers' housing frustrations. Every moment of online attention, whether through humor, video clips, or social interaction, went directly back into a message of economic relief and structural reform. Mamdani's ability to merge social media with material policy contrasts sharply with Harris's emphasis on tone and symbolism. Where Brat Summer produced visibility without a clear agenda, Mamdani's digital presence uses the same platforms to communicate urgency and solutions to economic insecurity.

His success highlights what McClurg (2006) and Theiss-Morse and Wagner (2023) identify as the key elements of effective political communication. Participation grows when messages connect to informed discussion networks and when emotional engagement is linked to meaningful content. Mamdani's posts generate both by making entertaining social media posts that spark policy discussion. Harris's campaign instead treated aesthetics as a substitute for a concrete platform, amplifying cultural relevance without addressing voters' material concerns. Mamdani transformed virality into civic mobilization, while Brat Summer turned virality into spectacle. While the urban mayoral race is quite unlike a national presidential campaign in terms of size and demographics, Mamdani's campaign has achieved a national reach with polling to back it up. In a political environment defined by economic dissatisfaction, substantive messaging made the difference between Mamdani's unprecedented success so far in New York and Harris's loss in 2024.

The failure of the Harris campaign demonstrates the limits of social media attention in modern politics. While the Brat Summer strategy captured online attention, it failed to translate that visibility into voter turnout. As the Michigan Model explains, voters filter short-term cues through long-term party identity and retrospective evaluations of government performance. In 2024, those evaluations were overwhelmingly focused on the economy, and Harris's cultural rebrand could not overcome the perception that she represented continuity with an administration that failed to alleviate inflation and wage stagnation. By leaning into the Brat aesthetic, she reinforced the partisan stereotypes that Ahler and Sood (2018) show deepen polarization, narrowing her appeal to moderates while failing to mobilize younger voters.

McClurg's (2006) findings explain the gap between enthusiasm and participation: political communication fosters turnout when it circulates through social networks and

deliberative discussion, not through one-way marketing campaigns. Harris's strategy energized those already attached to the Democratic Party but could not convert cultural enthusiasm into electoral momentum. Narrell's (2025) quantitative research confirms this pattern, memes generate awareness, not votes. To shift voter behavior, political messaging must be rooted in substantive policy appeals that address material concerns. While operating in a different context, Zohran Mamdani's campaign illustrates this distinction: his policy-focused messaging transforms social-media attention into meaningful civic engagement by meeting voters' economic frustrations with concrete solutions.

Ultimately, Brat Summer underscores that online attention is not political participation. Cultural relevance can capture the interests of voters and algorithms, but successful campaigns require credibility and substance. Campaigns that rely on spectacle without grounding their message in policy risk turning virality into noise. Harris's defeat is consistent with theories of voter behavior and illustrates the key differences between campaign success and failure. Visibility without vision is unsustainable, because aesthetics cannot substitute for policy-based persuasion, especially in a political moment defined by polarization, economic anxiety, and distrust. Campaigns that mistake virality for persuasion end up chasing attention, not votes.

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